

► **Star image on barn**

The Pennsylvania Dutch painted vividly exact stars on their barns, probably as stylized images of the unchanging heavens.

Pennsylvania Dutch

From the early 18th century, the German-speaking settlers of Pennsylvania made their mark on their new home, and it mainly took the literal form of boldly painted stars. These star motifs appeared on buildings such as barns and on almost every object they produced, from quilts to butter dishes.

Although some have claimed that the stars are hex signs against malignant forces, the real explanation for their use is both more prosaic and more universal. The Pennsylvania Dutch were farmers, acutely aware of the passing seasons. There was no more obvious symbol of natural cycles than the celestial order, evidence of a vast cosmos that dwarfed all human efforts.

Pow-wows

The publication in 1820 of German healer and mystic Johann George Hohman's *Pow-Wows; or, Long-Lost Friend* introduced a new magical variant. The book was an exuberant rehashing of earlier texts, which he had shamelessly plagiarized. It was part practical advice—cures for rheumatism, how to brew beer, how to treat a sick cow—and part mystical posturing. Mere possession of the volume, Hohman asserted, would protect the holder.

The book also introduced the term “pow-wow” for this semi-magical condition, and its advocates were known as pow-wowers. The name was possibly a corruption of a local term used by the indigenous Narragansett people for a spiritual gathering. Or it might have been a doctored version of the word “power.”



“Wild-fire and the dragon, flew over a wagon,
The wild-fire abated and the dragon skated.”